UKPA Presents

Working with Polyamorous People

for Mental Health Professionals

Written by a group of UKPA volunteers who work in the sphere of mental health and are themselves polyamorous.



Further Reading

Asebiomo, M. (2022). It's My Pleasure: Decolonizing Sex Positivity.

Barker, M.J. (2018). Rewriting the Rules: An Anti Self-Help Guide to Love, Sex and Relationships (2nd ed.). Routledge.

Fern, J. (2020). Polysecure: Attachment, trauma and consensual nonmonogamy. Thorntree Press LLC.

Ferrer, J. N. (2021). Love and freedom: Transcending monogamy and polyamory. Rowman & Littlefield.

Fosse, M. J. (2021). The many faces of polyamory: Longing and belonging in concurrent relationships. Routledge.

Goerlich, S. (2022). Kink-Affirming Practice: Culturally Competent Therapy from the Leather Chair (1st ed.). Routledge.

Kauppi, M. (2021). Polyamory: A Clinical Toolkit for Therapists (and Their Clients). Rowman & Littlefield Publishers.

Thouin, M. (2024). What is compersion? Understanding Positive Empathy in Consensually Nonmonogamous Relationships. Rowman & Littlefield.

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You can find an even more comprehensive reading list at **www.ukpolyamory.org**

Reflections

This is a space to write your own reflections on polyamory or to note any questions you might have...

Understanding Polyamory

Polyamory is a form of Ethical or Consensual Non-Monogamy (E/CNM), both of which are umbrella terms describing various types of non-monogamous connections where people develop relations with multiple others with the consent of all existing partners.

The word 'polyamory' comes from Ancient Greek and Latin and can be translated as 'many loves'. As this suggests, the emphasis in polyamory is on building and maintaining multiple loving relationships, not just sexual connections.

One can be polyamorous at one point in their life and later not, and vice versa. Some see their polyamory as a choice and others as part of their identity.

Often, polyamorous individuals have reflected on societal, cultural, and at times religious teachings about what is considered a 'typical' relationship structure. Similar to individuals who have questioned their gender identity, sexual orientation, religious beliefs, views on marriage and parenthood, etc, some individuals question relational flexibility and find fulfilment in ethically non-monogamous connections.

Research indicates that consensual non-monogamy often features:

- well-developed skills in communication and emotional processing
- emphasis on honesty and negotiated boundaries
- increased experiences of trust and emotional intimacy.

These can function as strengths and protective factors in mental wellbeing.

Clinical Considerations

Despite increasing visibility, individuals may choose to hide their polyamorous identity due to:

- fear of discrimination
- stigma or misunderstanding
- limited recognition in formal systems (e.g. healthcare, legal, administrative forms).

This can affect disclosure, trust, and engagement in mental health appointments.

You do not need to share or agree with a client's relationship style to work effectively with them. However, guidance for best practice includes:

- avoiding pathologising non-monogamy
- creating a safe space for clients to disclose
- reflecting on your own assumptions and emotional responses
- building cultural sensitivity through additional reading and learning
- staying curious, not assumptive.

To build a poly-inclusive practice, approach polyamory as you would any other aspect of diversity.



Common Terms

It is important to use the person's own language and meaning-making, but below is a short list of some common terms that a client might mention and their widely accepted meanings:

Compersion - Joy in a partner's happiness derived from other relationships

E/CNM - Ethical/Consensual Non-Monogamy

Metamour/s - Partner's other partner/s

NRE - New Relationship Energy; often mentioned when a new connection is developing alongside existing relationship/s

Polycule - Network of interconnected relationships

Primary - A person's main partner

Relationship Anarchy - Non-hierarchical way of seeing relationships

Solo Polyamory - Emphasis on individual autonomy and relationship with self alongside relationships, e.g. choosing to live alone

Triads/Throuples - Relationships involving three people

Important Distinctions

Polyamory and other forms of E/CNM are often mistaken for, but not the same as:

Infidelity - Developing new romantic or sexual relations while having another partner who is not aware or consenting to this

Polygamy - Having multiple wives

Thank you for taking the time to learn about polyamory. If you are interested in learning more, visit our website: **www.ukpolyamory.org**

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